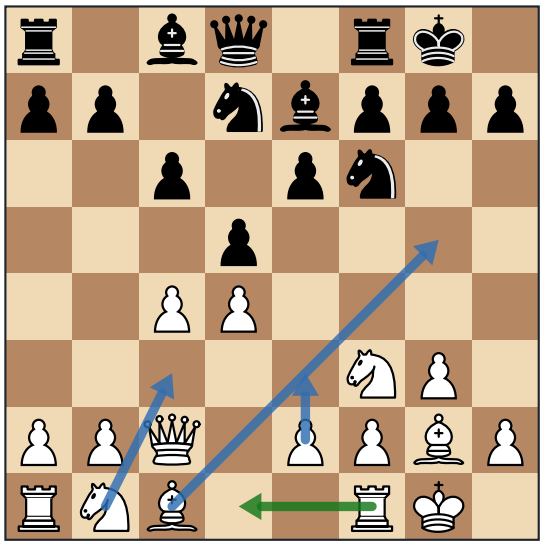
Catalan Opening

ECO E00-E09 | 32 named lines | Nimzo / Queen's Indian / Catalan family

In one sentence: Flexible, high-level systems: Black controls e4 with pieces; White fights with the bishop pair, the center or a fianchetto.

Memory pattern: Control e4 with pieces, then break with ...d5 or ...c5.



Main line: 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nf3 O-O 6.O-O Nbd7 7.Qc2 c6

Key ideas

1. Nimzo: pin Nc3 and fight for e4; trade the bishop for knight to damage structure.
2. Queen's Indian: Bb7 and ...Be7 control e4 without weaknesses.
3. Catalan: use the long diagonal and queenside pressure.
4. Bogo-Indian: solid, flexible and low-risk for Black.
5. Plans revolve around e4, the c-file, and whether White gets the bishop pair.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **+0.42** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best: Rd1.

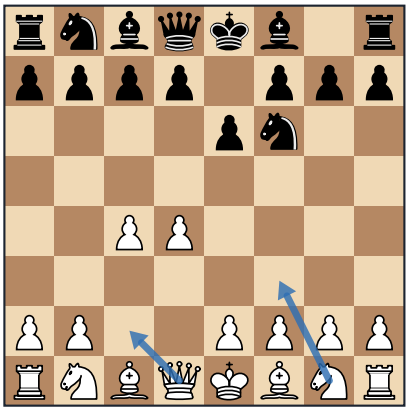
The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Black controls e4 with pieces (pin on c3 or Bb7) while White takes the c4/d4 centre or the bishop pair. Catalan: White uses g3/Bg2 pressure on d5 and the long diagonal.
2. Where does my king go?	Kings castle short; Black often keeps a healthy pawn structure by giving up the bishop pair.
3. Best minor pieces?	Black: Bb4/Bb7 and the long diagonal. White: Nc3, Bd3, Qc2, e4 break; Catalan: Bg2, Qc2, Nbd2.
4. Main middlegame plan?	White occupies the centre with e4 or plays a3/Bxc3 structures; Black strikes with ...d5/...c5 and piece pressure.
5. What does my opponent want?	White wants the bishop pair and a big centre; Black wants to restrain e4 and hit the centre.

The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nf3 O-O 6.O-O Nbd7 7.Qc2 c6

Move	Why it is played
1. d4	Take the center. Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... Nf6	Develops the knight to f6.
2. c4	Space. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
2... e6	Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
3. g3	Fianchetto. Gains space on the wing.
3... d5	Central break. Occupies the center with a pawn.
4. Bg2	Long diagonal. Fianchetto: the bishop takes the long diagonal.
4... Be7	Develops the bishop to e7.
5. Nf3	Develops the knight to f3.
5... O-O	Castles: the king reaches safety and the rook joins the center.
6. O-O	Castles: the king reaches safety and the rook joins the center.
6... Nbd7	Develops the knight to d7.
7. Qc2	Flexible queen. Queen move: puts pressure on a target (watch for tempo-gaining attacks).
7... c6	Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.



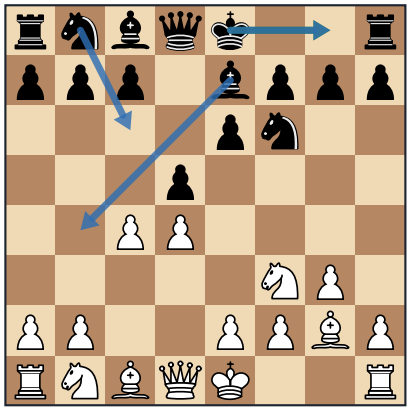
After 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6



After 4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.Bg2 Be7

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

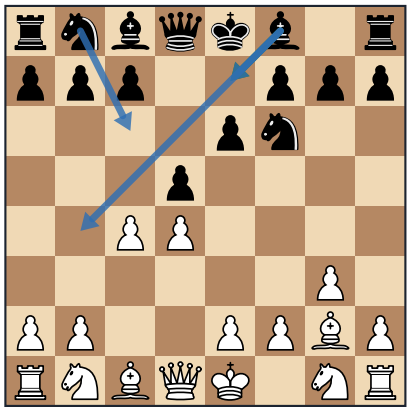


Position after the line

Closed E06 | 17 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nf3`

Stockfish: **+0.17** (equal, depth 15). Best next move: O-O.
What to look for: Nf6 (develop); e6 (solid); Bb4 (pin Nc3)
Sub-variations: Main Line, Botvinnik Variation, Spassky Gambit, Zagoryansky Variation

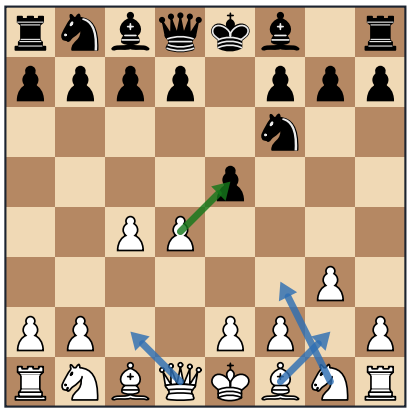


Position after the line

Open Defense E01 | 9 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.Bg2`

Stockfish: **+0.28** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: Be7.
What to look for: Nf6 (develop); e6 (solid); Bb4 (pin Nc3)
Sub-variations: Classical Line, Alekhine Variation, Modern Sharp Variation

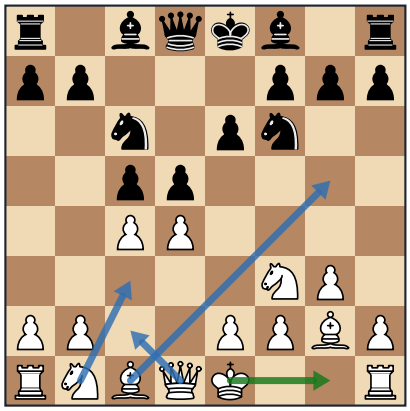


Position after the line

Hungarian Gambit E00 | 1 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 e5`

Stockfish: **+1.09** (clearly better for White, depth 15). Best next move: dxe5.
What to look for: d4 (take the center); c4 (space); Nc3 (develop)



Position after the line

Tarrasch Defense E01 | 1 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.Bg2 c5 5.Nf3 Nc6`

Stockfish: **+0.31** (slightly better for White, depth 15). Best next move: O-O.
What to look for: d4 (take the center); c4 (space); Nc3 (develop)

Detailed repertoire notes

Catalan (E04-E09, White)

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nf3 O-O 6.O-O dxc4 7.Qc2 a6 8.Qxc4 b5 9.Qc2 Bb7 10.Bd2`

Idea: Use the long diagonal against d5/b7 and keep a small, lasting initiative.

Structure: Open Catalan: White gets a queenside initiative after taking c4; Closed Catalan: White keeps a central grip and squeezes.

Pieces: Bg2 (best), knights d2-b3, queen c2, rooks c1/d1. The h1-a8 diagonal is the main asset.

Plan: Pressure c6/d5, play Qc2 and Nbd2, then e4 or queenside expansion with b3, Bb2. In open lines, win back c4 and keep the initiative.

King: Castle early; Bg2 shields the king. **Opponent:** ...dxc4 and ...b5 to keep the pawn, or ...c5 to trade your center.

Watch out: Black may hold with solid ...c6/...Nbd7; patience is required, not early forcing.

Expert and coach view

Nimzowitsch (Nimzo-Indian), Karpov and Kramnik (Catalan) are strongly linked to these systems.

What a coach would tell you

Learn the key structure: doubled c-pawns versus bishop pair (Nimzo), the long diagonal fight (Catalan) and the e4 break. Play solid, flexible moves and avoid early commitments.

Why play it

Flexible, high-level systems: Black controls e4 with pieces; White fights with the bishop pair, the center or a fianchetto.

Typical mistakes

- Giving up the bishop pair without compensation (Nimzo).
- Playing ...d5 too early before the pieces are developed.
- Letting White play e4 with a big center unopposed.

Typical tactics and traps

- Bxc3 followed by Ng5 or e4 winning the pinned knight if Black is careless.
- Qa4+ forks after ...b5 in Catalan lines.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Balanced endgames with small edges decided by structure and bishops.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Catalan Opening (all lines)** — E00
  `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.g3`
  - **Closed Variation** — E09
    `1.d4`
    - **Rabinovich Variation** — E09
      `1.d4 -> 1...d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Qc2 e6 5.Nbd2 Be7 6.g3 Nbd7 7.Bg2 O-O 8.O-O b5`
    - **Traditional Variation** — E09
      `1.d4 -> 1...Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 d5 4.g3 Be7 5.Bg2 O-O 6.O-O Nbd7 7.Qc2 c6 8.Nbd2 b6`
  - **Hungarian Gambit** — E00
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 -> 3...e5`
  - **Open Defense** — E01
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 -> 3...d5 4.Bg2`
    - **Classical Line** — E05
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.Bg2 -> 4...dxc4 5.Nf3 Be7`
    - **Modern Sharp Variation** — E04
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.Bg2 -> 4...dxc4 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.Qa4 Bb4`
    - **Alekhine Variation** — E03
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.Bg2 -> 4...dxc4 5.Qa4 Nbd7 6.Qxc4 a6 7.Qc2`
  - **Closed** — E06
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 -> 3...d5 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nf3`
    - **Botvinnik Variation** — E07
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nf3 -> 5...O-O 6.O-O Nbd7 7.Nc3 c6 8.Qd3`
    - **Main Line** — E09
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 d5 4.g3 Be7 5.Bg2 O-O 6.O-O Nbd7 7.Qc2 c6 8.Nbd2`
    - **Zagoryansky Variation** — E08
      `1.d4 e6 2.c4 Nf6 3.Nf3 d5 4.g3 Be7 5.Bg2 O-O 6.O-O Nbd7 7.Qc2 c6 8.Rd1 b6 9.a4`
    - **Sokolsky Variation** — E09
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nf3 -> 5...O-O 6.O-O Nbd7 7.Qc2 c6 8.Nbd2 b6 9.b3 a5 10.Bb2 Ba6`
    - **Spassky Gambit** — E08
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 Be7 4.Bg2 d5 5.Nf3 O-O 6.O-O Nbd7 7.Qc2 c6 8.b3 b6 9.Rd1 Bb7 10.Nc3 b5`
  - **Tarrasch Defense** — E01
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 -> 3...d5 4.Bg2 c5 5.Nf3 Nc6`

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

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1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nf3 0-0
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Plan chain

White	d4 -> c4 -> Nc3 -> Nf3 -> g3
Black	Nf6 -> e6 -> Bb4 -> b6 -> Bb7

Three rules to remember

1. Control e4 with pieces, then break with ...d5 or ...c5.

2. White occupies the centre with e4 or plays a3/Bxc3 structures; Black strikes with ...d5/...c5 and piece pressure.

3. White wants the bishop pair and a big centre; Black wants to restrain e4 and hit the centre.

Pawn structure in one line

Black controls e4 with pieces (pin on c3 or Bb7) while White takes the c4/d4 centre or the bishop pair. Catalan: White uses g3/Bg2 pressure on d5 and the long diagonal.